Caliphate issue was one which captured the imagination of the public.[142] As one historian has explained, 'Turkey became a symbol of the past greatness of Islam and its predicament in a hostile world in the twentieth century'.[143] And with Gandhi encouraging Hindus to support the Muslim cause, the movement gained true mass appeal in India, much to the discomfort of the government.[144]

In January, Chelmsford tried to diffuse the situation by reassuring a Caliphate deputation that the views of Indian Muslims were being strenuously pressed at the peace conference in Paris, and that within the British Empire the religion, lives and property of Muslims had and always would be protected.[145] Unfortunately the viceroy's statements did not convince the deputation, which put out a statement that 'should the peace terms result unfavourably to Muslim religion and sentiments, they would place undue strain upon Muslim loyalty'.[146]At a Caliphate conference held in Bengal on 28 February 1920 a resolution was passed stating that:

if the settlement of peace with Turkey is in any way against the religious injunctions and demands of Islam, that is, if the dominions of the Khilafate are not kept intact as they were before the war, then Muslims in obedience to the laws of Islam will be compelled to cease all relations of loyalty with Great Britain and shall be duty bound to assist their Khalif against all his enemies by all possible means.[147]

Despite the viceroy's attempts to prevent it, the sentiment was growing in the Muslim world that the British Empire, once the friend of Islam, was increasingly its enemy.

Unable to counter the Caliphate movement with reason and theory, and finding that its calls for Muslim loyalty were also being rebuffed, the Indian government chose to handle the situation by remaining as uninvolved as possible. Chelmsford explained to Montagu in March, that 'at the present moment the extremists are somewhat in a quandary. They would like to attack the Government of India, but there is nothing on which they can take